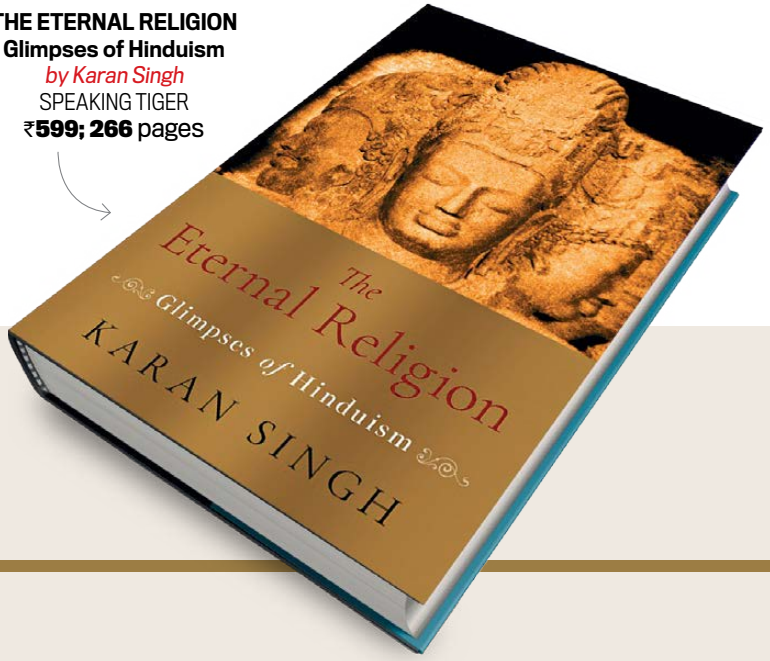
BOOKS

Belief and Beyond

THE ETERNAL RELIGION
Glimpses of Hinduism
by Karan Singh
SPEAKING TIGER
₹**599; 266** pages



***THE ETERNAL RELIGION*, KARAN SINGH'S SEMINAL BOOK ON HINDUISM, DISTILS DECADES OF SCHOLARSHIP AND WISDOM**

The book under review shows seven decades of spiritual curiosity and the answers it has revealed. Anyone who wants to compact their journey and not be lost in the deep sea of Hinduism can greatly benefit from this book where both the physical symbols and the abstract concepts are lucidly explained.

The long opening essay, an overview of Hinduism, is outstanding in its depth and range, asserting the superiority of a generous and accommodative way of thinking beyond the myopias, which the world has long called religions. It explains how Hinduism isn't the vision of one individual. Nor was it written as a single book gospel, but is the collective wisdom of seers and sages, transmitted orally and distilled over the ages, before eventually being written down. That it was interpreted by participation and remained flexible added to its inclusivity. Hinduism was so wide and abstract that those born under its umbrella felt no insecurity or obligation for proselytism.

The book explains Hinduism in five tenets. It talks of the abstract Vedas, the Upanishads or Vedanta as the end of the Vedas, and the more mundane Puranas, for the unlettered. Karan Singh simplifies Brahman—the cosmic permanent, the Aatman—the undying, immortal spark in man; the link between the two as one or dual, or even similar, but separate; the spiritual elevation process of trying to transcend these definitions; and the fifth and important tenet of Karma, action without seeking its rewards. He writes: "... far from implying fatalism, as is often wrongly, believed, Karma gives tremendous responsibility to the individual and places in his own hands, the key to his future Destiny."

The third part of the book does retro-trips of Singh's earlier writings. His pilgrimages make for a good read, particularly his Amarnath yatra of 1953, where a five-foot stalagmite discovered by Muslim Bakarwals is imbued with Hindu symbols and worshipped as holy, while it is only one more manifestation of pristine nature. The author writes that the offerings in cash and kind received at Amarnath are distributed in three equal parts by the pilgrimage Mahanti at Srinagar; the priest of Mattan, en route to Pahalgam; and the Muslim Malicks! "The gleaming ice lingam possesses a strange power of attraction," writes Singh.

Perhaps **DR KARAN SINGH** held his mentor Jawaharlal Nehru in such high esteem that his 'eternal religion' was pitted and outwitted against Modernism

Singh is caught in the many roles of prince, maharaja, academic and precocious politician whose career was embittered when his party thought of lesser mortals for the post of President when he would have certainly made India proud. He also played the distracted patriarch of the Dogras and his family while being a regular Page Three favourite for openings and book releases. Perhaps Dr Karan Singh held his mentor Jawaharlal Nehru in such high esteem that his 'eternal religion' was pitted and outwitted against Modernism. Since Singh's role model was not Ramakrishna Paramahansa, will he be remembered as our new-age Vivekananda? ■

–Aman Nath